

College education is not only about developing career-relevant skills—it is also a formative time for exploration and growth. Students discover what excites them, how they can engage with the world, and how to think critically about the questions that matter. Being part of that growth motivates my teaching philosophy, which rests on four goals: (i) excite students about science, (ii) cultivate critical thinking skills, (iii) engage students with active research, and (iv) create an inclusive learning environment.

Excite students about science: Students learn best when they are genuinely engaged. To spark excitement, I bring my own enthusiasm for biological anthropology into the classroom and highlight the field's dynamic and evolving nature. Because new discoveries, methods, and debates continually reshape our understanding of human evolution, students can see themselves at the forefront of knowledge rather than simply absorbing static facts. To keep students engaged, I incorporate active learning techniques—pairing lectures with interspersed clicker questions, small group discussions, and hands-on activities—strategies which have also been shown to boost knowledge retention and encourage creative thinking and collaboration.

Stimulate critical thinking skills: In a world of rapidly generated media, AI tools, and constant information streams, critical thinking is an essential life skill. One of the most effective ways to cultivate it is through engaging directly with primary scientific literature. In my courses, I train students to read research articles with a critical eye—identifying hypotheses, evaluating methods, weighing conclusions against data, and distinguishing speculation from evidence. To scaffold this process, I pair seminal papers that shaped a field with more recent studies that challenge or refine their conclusions. This approach not only helps students grasp the dynamic nature of scientific knowledge but also empowers them to situate findings within broader theoretical debates and generate their own informed conclusions. By the end of my courses, students are not only more confident in navigating the literature but also better equipped to apply evidence-based reasoning across their careers and daily lives.

Engage students with active research: I want all students—whether in an introductory class or a research program—to experience the scientific process firsthand. In mentorship settings, I guide students in developing independent projects that align with their interests and strengths. In the classroom, I integrate authentic datasets, such as those from open data repositories, and challenge students to ask questions, analyze evidence, and draw conclusions. These experiences show that the skills learned in biological anthropology are not confined to specialized research but are transferable to broader problem-solving and civic engagement.

Create an inclusive learning environment: In my teaching, I will continually strive to create an inclusive and engaging classroom where all students feel welcome and supported. To do so, I will establish clear, explicit expectations for participation, performance, and engagement so that students understand how to succeed first and foremost. I am also committed to providing course content which highlights diverse perspectives, experiences, and contributions to the field. To improve the accessibility of my courses, I will provide materials in multiple formats, spanning from primary readings to lectures and podcasts, as well as hands-on activities and discussions. Similarly, I will incorporate varied and formative assessment methods that allow all students to demonstrate understanding in multiple ways throughout the class term. Finally, I will continuously reflect on my teaching practices, using student feedback, performance data, and learning analytics to improve my courses and ensure that they effectively support the learning of every student.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Throughout my career, I have taught a range of classes and guest lectures in biological anthropology. As a graduate student, I led the laboratory sections of *Human Evolution* at New York University and *Introduction to Human Evolution* at Hunter College (CUNY). These entry-level undergraduate courses attracted students from diverse majors fulfilling science requirements, which meant working with a wide range of backgrounds and experience levels. I saw these courses as opportunities to spark excitement about science and inspire undecided students to pursue biological anthropology. In 2020, I taught *Human*

Evolution during the COVID-19 pandemic, when NYU's anthropology department was piloting new interactive online learning modules. As part of the first group of TAs to teach under this format, I gained valuable experience in online instruction and in adapting course content in real time based on both student and instructor feedback. This experience helped me develop strategies for fostering interactive learning in large classes and virtual settings. Beyond leading lab sections, I guest lectured in NYU's *Human Evolution* course on "Primate Behavior" and "Primate Physiology," and as a postdoc, I have lectured in Vanderbilt's graduate-level *Big Data for Biologists* course on "Data Wrangling and Visualization" and "Advanced Data Visualization and Reproducibility" in R. In addition to these experiences, I further honed my teaching skills through two teaching certification courses- "Inclusive Teaching in the College Classroom" offered through Columbia University and "Preparing Future Faculty: Achieving Success Through Communication" at New York University. Through these programs, I learned to implement engaging and inclusive learning techniques, diversify course materials, navigate sensitive topics, and accommodate persons with disabilities.

Outside of the classroom, my commitment to science outreach is reflected in both formal training and community engagement. I completed a one-month science communication workshop at NYU to strengthen my ability to convey scientific concepts to broad audiences and served as a science writing associate at the New York Academy of Sciences (2016–2018), where I summarized scientific symposia and events for non-specialist readers. At Vanderbilt, I have enjoyed participating in the Evolutionary Studies Initiative's outreach programs, leading evolution-themed exhibits and educational booths at community events organized by the Girl Scouts, the Nashville Predators, the Nashville Zoo, and Metro Parks Nashville. I deeply believe that science should be accessible and engaging to learners of all ages and will continue my commitment to science outreach and communication as a faculty member.

MENTORING EXPERIENCE

I have had the privilege of mentoring students at every stage of training, from high schoolers to graduate students, which has been the most rewarding aspect of my academic career. Through programs at NYU and Vanderbilt, I have mentored six high school students from underrepresented backgrounds as they navigated the college application process and engaged in intensive summer research. I helped them develop their independent research questions and projects, which ranged from behavioral data collection at local zoos to bioinformatic analyses of genomic datasets. Each student presented their results at program symposia, with two earning awards for their work at Vanderbilt, and two earning co-authorship on a publication in *Scientific Reports*. Beyond these programs, I have mentored undergraduates and graduate students on independent research. For example, I worked closely with an undergraduate who used data that I collected during my dissertation to test questions about the timing of ovulation in the olive baboon, earning her an award at her Undergraduate Research Symposium. In addition, I mentored her in the wet lab, providing her with hands-on experience in molecular techniques resulting in her co-authorship on a manuscript currently in revision at *PLOS Biology*. As a postdoctoral researcher, I continue to mentor graduate students with the goal of equipping them to become self-sufficient researchers. I guide them in mastering wet-lab and computational methods, developing effective writing strategies, and navigating professional growth, while encouraging them to take ownership of their projects.

Together, my teaching philosophy and experience make me qualified to teach a broad range of undergraduate and graduate level courses. I would be excited to lead courses that are already offered at the University of New Mexico, including "Introduction to Biological Anthropology", "Human Biology", and "Human Genetics and Genomics". In addition to these established course offerings, I would be excited to develop new courses that complement the existing offerings, including topics such as "Epigenetics and the Biology of Aging", "Quantitative Methods in Evolutionary Anthropology", and "Methods in Evolutionary Genomics". These courses could be implemented as lectures or more advanced hands-on computing or wet-lab courses, which I believe would complement and strengthen the current curriculum. Lastly, my research program and collaborative field sites will provide excellent training opportunities for students in computational, laboratory, and field-based approaches.